AI in critical sectors: Bridging systematic gaps

The UN's 2030 Agenda is crystal clear: progress must be inclusive and sustainable. In AI, we find a tool capable of powering that progress if wielded wisely.

Agriculture (SDG 2): AI and IoT (Internet of Things) are revolutionising food security. They are being deployed to guide irrigation schedules, monitor soil conditions, and detect pest infestations. Subsistence farmers in South Africa and Brazil are beginning to access tools once reserved for industrial-scale farmers (also known as commercial farming), thanks to AI-powered apps that work even on low-cost smartphones.

Healthcare (SDG 3): AI has already demonstrated its value in low-resource settings. It can dramatically improve access and quality in under-resourced clinics. Machine learning models are proving effective in diagnosing diseases like tuberculosis, retinopathy, and certain cancers from low-cost scans, overcoming the shortage of specialised medical personnel in rural areas. Telemedicine platforms, powered by AI triage systems, are extending care reach across vast geographical distances in countries like Russia and India.

Education (SDG 4): Machine learning platforms are tailoring content to students' individual needs, improving learning outcomes for children in overcrowded or under-resourced schools. For communities long excluded from quality education, this represents a potential game-changer.

Governance (SDG 16): AI tools are enhancing public service delivery, optimising urban planning, and combating corruption through anomaly detection in public spending.

However, the efficacy of AI deployment is jeopardised without deliberate policy intervention. If AI systems are trained on biased data sets that reflect existing gender, racial, or socio-economic disparities, they risk reinforcing, rather than reducing, systemic inequalities. Deliberate policy is thus required to ensure AI-driven progress translates into inclusive growth.

Opportunities and risks for the BRICS+ agenda

For the BRICS+ nations, AI presents an unprecedented opportunity to leapfrog traditional stages of industrialisation and technological development. By strategically adopting AI, member states can diversify their economies, moving rapidly up the manufacturing and services value chains (SDG 9). This strategic investment fosters technological sovereignty, a key priority for the expanded BRICS bloc seeking a multipolar economic landscape.

The integration and collaboration within the BRICS+ framework are critical here. Shared AI research hubs, cross-border data governance standards, and investment from the New Development Bank (NDB) into AI infrastructure can pool resources and expertise, creating a truly South-South innovation ecosystem.



Yet, this ambitious vision is accompanied by significant risks that must be proactively managed.

Algorithmic bias and digital divide

AI models trained without adequate representation of diverse BRICS+ populations risk inheriting and amplifying biases, leading to discriminatory outcomes in lending, policing, and hiring. Furthermore, the divide between countries that innovate and produce AI and those that merely consume proprietary Western technology threatens to widen global economic disparities, hindering the goal of a balanced global technology order.

Data privacy and security

The efficacy of AI is directly tied to the availability of massive data sets. This necessitates robust, common standards for data privacy and security. A failure to implement strong regulatory frameworks risks widespread data exploitation and potential violations of citizen rights.

Labour Market Disruption (SDG 8)

While AI promises increased productivity, its rapid automation could displace workers in sectors fundamental to BRICS+ economies, particularly low-skilled manufacturing and processing jobs. Planning for massive upskilling and reskilling initiatives is paramount to ensure technological advancement does not lead to mass unemployment and social instability.

Countering these challenges requires a dual focus, establishing comprehensive ethical frameworks and aggressively investing in local innovation ecosystems. Ethical guidelines must be rooted in the values and social contexts of the Global South, prioritising fairness, transparency, and accountability. Simultaneously, strategic investment in local talent, data infrastructure, and computational power is essential to foster indigenous AI development that is both culturally relevant and aligned with national development priorities.

Towards a cooperative AI future

The alignment of AI with the Sustainable Development Goals is perhaps the most defining technological challenge for the BRICS+ community this decade. AI is not a magic bullet, but a sophisticated tool whose effectiveness depends on the policy architecture surrounding it.

The BRICS+ nations, collectively representing a majority of the world's population and burgeoning economies, possess the scale and political will to champion a new model of AI development. One that prioritises human-centric, ethical deployment and South-South collaboration. By cooperating on data governance, sharing best practices, and strategically funding local R&D, the bloc can ensure that AI catalyses equitable progress, securing not just technological dominance, but genuinely inclusive growth for all its members and the wider Global South.